visitor to Akbar's court, too, would be astounded by the Padshah's accessibility, even after the rules of etiquette had coalesced into something much more rigid. 'It is hard to exaggerate how accessible he makes himself to all who wish audience of him,' wrote Father Monserrate, the Jesuit, 'for he creates an opportunity almost every day for any of the common people or of the nobles to see him and converse with him; and he endeavours to show himself pleasant-spoken and affable, rather than severe, toward all who come to speak with him.' Jesuit reports from this period give us an excellent description of the young Padshah. According to them, he was 'a fine-looking, broad-shouldered man, but bow-legged, and of a swarthy complexion. His eyes are large but with narrow openings, like those of a Tartar or Chinaman. He has a broad, open forehead; and his nose, except for a slight lump in the centre, is straight. The nostrils are large, and on the left one there is a small wart. He is in the habit of carrying his head slightly inclined to the right side. Like the Turks, he shaves his beard; but he wears a small neatly trimmed moustache.'

These traits that Akbar displayed as a young emperor—his intense curiosity, his ferocious courage, and his warm approachability with both commoners and noblemen alike, would run like a thread throughout his long reign, allowing him to make bonds of friendship with the most unlikely of allies. But there were shows of unexpected anger, rare but explosive; one such episode erupted in a particularly spectacular manner, scorching the very heart of Akbar's ancient bonds of love—his foster family.

Ever since Adham Khan had been recalled from Malwa and Ataka Khan named wakil, violence had simmered under the surface of courtly life at Agra. Adham Khan, most tempestuous of Akbar's kokas, considered himself beyond chastisement because of the young Padshah's unfailing courtesy towards members of his foster family. But a reckoning was about to come for Adham Khan on a blazing day in May.

When Ataka Khan was made wakil he, along with the eunuch Itimad Khan, set about improving the state's revenues by increasing the state's share in jagirs which had long been in default. Plans were put in place to improve revenue administration and 'the royal revenues, which were in the hands of embezzlers' were handed over to Itimad Khan. The influence of Maham Anaga, Munim Khan, and Adham Khan was curtailed and reduced and this was a new reality that Adham Khan could not tolerate. In the